wanted to know when action would be taken—even though VOC was in prison.)

VOC's verse autobiography confirms this intrigue and provides details though exact dates are missing. At first—probably in late 1907—VOC was asked to travel and raise capital, the motive, no doubt, being to deprive him of the oxygen of public support. Initially, he was sent to Calicut. Then, through oral instructions and written orders, he was despatched to various places. VOC acquiesced in the interests of the company, believing that it was best to keep away from Tuticorin for a while. But matters came to a head on his return to Tuticorin, after the Surat imbroglio. The directors now pressurized him to resign from the company. Only two directors—S.T.A. Arumugam Pillai and A.M.M. Arunachalam Pillai—stood by him, arguing that the company would collapse without him. The moderate cabal argued that VOC had resigned on his own and not under duress and said that he could now be appointed as a salaried agent. However, they were unhappy even with this designation, deciding to call him a 'superintendent'. (In response to a pointed question from the governor, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar clarified that he was not 'a superintendent' but 'an agent'.[29] VOC's wife Meenakshi also makes reference to this designation.[30]) Insult was being added to injury. But whatever the designation, VOC felt that it was his duty to stand by the company. Here there is a possible confusion in the sequence of events narrated by VOC, but a police report of 8 February 1908 states that VOC was given a salaried appointment as agent on a salary of Rs 100 per month,[31] while Guruswami Aiyar gave a figure of Rs 200 in his meeting with the governor.[32] However, at the same time, S. Gurunathaiyar, the police head constable known for his Swadeshi sympathies, was appointed as cargo superintendent of SSNCo. This was no doubt VOC's handiwork. Despite his evident loss of authority, it appears that he continued to have his way within the company.

All the above intrigues happened behind the screen. But it could not be kept under wraps for long. Though he did not publicly elaborate on the conflict within the company, VOC did allude to it in some of his speeches.